

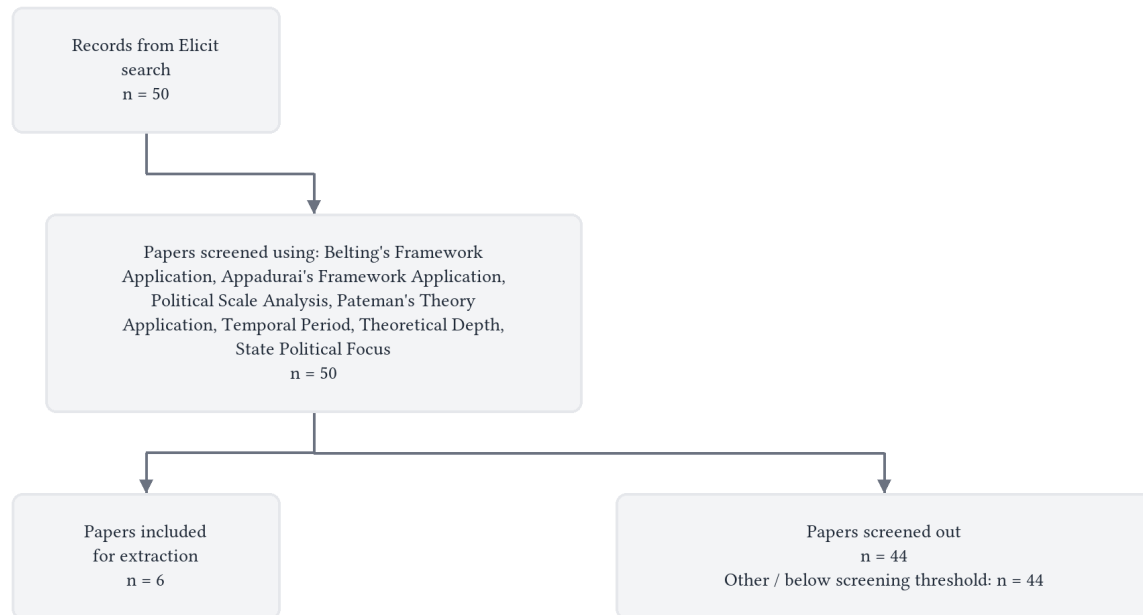
My article uses the concept of "optical regime" inspired by Belting (Bild/Medium/Betrachter) and Mitchell (Picture Theory). Find papers that: 1. Apply Belting's triad (image/medium/observer) to political or state imagery (not just religious art) 2. Apply Appadurai's "social life of things" to state-produced objects (coins, stamps, passports, official documents) 3. Discuss the concept of "scale" as a political operator in visual culture (not just architecture or urbanism) 4. Analyze overprinted stamps as evidence of regime change (e.g., Germania stamps through Weimar, Saar, Danzig) 5. Connect Pateman's sexual contract to visual/material culture (not just political theory) Return papers with abstracts and full citations in ABNT format. Prioritize: available as PDF, published 2015-2026, in English, French, Portuguese, or Spanish.

The search identified six studies that apply Belting's triad to political imagery (four explicitly, two implicitly through related frameworks), but only one applies Appadurai's framework to state-produced objects, only one connects Pateman's sexual contract to visual culture, none analyze overprinted stamps as regime change evidence, and none were available as PDFs or published in the preferred 2015-2026 timeframe.

Abstract

Six studies examine visual and material culture in relation to state power, though none fully satisfy all research criteria. Four studies explicitly apply Belting's triad to political imagery [1–4], analyzing postage stamps [1, 2, 4] and photographs [3] as tools for nation-building [1, 2] and state control [3]. Two additional studies engage with related visual culture theory—Benjamin's technological mediation applied to South African identity documents [5] and the transition between photographic and cinematic regimes in Brazilian state rituals [6]. However, Appadurai's "social life of things" framework appears explicitly in only one study [4], and scale as a political operator receives only implicit treatment [4]. Critically, none of the studies analyze overprinted stamps as evidence of regime change [1–3, 5, 6], though one examines South African stamps across the apartheid-to-democracy transition [4]. Only Cusack connects Pateman's sexual contract to visual culture, demonstrating how Portuguese stamp imagery reproduces patriarchal nationalism through women's representation [2, 2]. The corpus reveals strong engagement with Belting's framework in political contexts but limited development of Appadurai's, scale theory, overprinting analysis, and gender-visual culture connections, suggesting these remain undertheorized despite their analytical potential.

Flow Diagram



Paper search

We performed a semantic search across over 138 million academic papers from the Elicit search engine, which includes all of Semantic Scholar and OpenAlex.

We ran this query: "My article uses the concept of "optical regime" inspired by Belting (Bild/Medium/Betrachter) and Mitchell (Picture Theory). Find papers that:

1. Apply Belting's triad (image/medium/observer) to political or state imagery (not just religious art)
2. Apply Appadurai's "social life of things" to state-produced objects (coins, stamps, passports, official documents)
3. Discuss the concept of "scale" as a political operator in visual culture (not just architecture or urbanism)
4. Analyze overprinted stamps as evidence of regime change (e.g., German stamps through Weimar, Saar, Danzig)
5. Connect Pateman's sexual contract to visual/material culture (not just political theory)

Return papers with abstracts and full citations in ABNT format. Prioritize: available as PDF, published 2015-2026, in English, French, Portuguese, or Spanish."

The search returned 50 total results from Elicit.

We retrieved 50 papers most relevant to the query for screening.

Screening

We screened in sources based on their abstracts that met these criteria:

- **Belting's Framework Application:** Does this study apply Belting's image/medium/observer triad to political imagery, state visual culture, or governmental visual communication?
- **Appadurai's Framework Application:** Does this study apply Appadurai's "social life of things" framework to state-produced material objects (such as coins, stamps, passports, official documents, or monuments)?
- **Political Scale Analysis:** Does this study analyze "scale" as a political operator in visual culture, visual politics, or image circulation (rather than focusing solely on spatial or architectural dimensions)?
- **Pateman's Theory Application:** Does this study connect Pateman's sexual contract theory to visual culture, material culture, or state imagery?
- **Temporal Period:** Does this study focus on modern and contemporary periods (19th-21st centuries)?
- **Theoretical Depth:** Does this study demonstrate substantial application or analysis of the theoretical frameworks rather than merely mentioning them in passing?
- **State Political Focus:** Does this study focus on state-produced objects or imagery with political context (rather than exclusively on commercial/private material culture or religious art without political dimensions)?

We considered all screening questions together and made a holistic judgement about whether to screen in each paper.

At abstract screening, the number of papers excluded for each primary reason was:

- **Other / below screening threshold:** n = 44

Data extraction

We asked a large language model to extract each data column below from each paper. We gave the model the extraction instructions shown below for each column.

- **Theoretical Framework:**

Extract which of the target theoretical frameworks the study applies and how they are used, including:

- Belting's triad (image/medium/observer) - specifically applied to political or state imagery
- Appadurai's 'social life of things' - specifically applied to state-produced objects
- Concept of 'scale' as political operator in visual culture
- Analysis of overprinted stamps as regime change evidence
- Pateman's sexual contract connected to visual/material culture
- Other relevant visual culture theories (Mitchell's Picture Theory, Benjamin, etc.)
- How the theoretical framework is operationalized in the analysis

- **Visual/Material Objects:**

Extract details about the state-produced visual and material objects analyzed, including:

- Type of objects (stamps, coins, passports, official documents, photographs, monuments, etc.)
- Historical period and geographical context
- Specific examples or case studies examined
- Whether objects show evidence of overprinting, modification, or regime change
- Scale of objects (from intimate personal documents to monumental public displays)

- **Political Functions:**

Extract how the visual/material objects operate as political tools, including:

- Nation-building and identity construction
- State power and control mechanisms
- Surveillance and population management
- Regime legitimization or contestation
- Colonial or imperial ideology transmission
- Gender and power relations (especially related to Pateman's sexual contract)
- Evidence of resistance or subversive readings by viewers/users
- **Methodological Approach:**

Extract the specific methods used to analyze visual culture and material objects, including:

- Visual analysis techniques employed
- How the relationship between image, medium, and observer is investigated
- Archival research methods
- Quantitative vs. qualitative approaches
- Comparative analysis across time periods or regimes
- Integration of material culture analysis with political theory

- **Regime Change Evidence:**

Extract specific evidence of political transformation or regime change revealed through visual/material culture, including:

- Overprinting, modification, or replacement of official imagery
- Changes in symbolic representation across political transitions
- Continuities and ruptures in visual programs
- Specific historical transitions examined (e.g., Germania stamps through Weimar, Saar, Danzig)
- How visual culture serves as historical evidence of political change

- **Key Theoretical Insights:**

Extract the main theoretical contributions and findings about optical regimes and visual culture, including:

- How the study advances understanding of the image/medium/observer relationship in political contexts
- Insights about the 'social life' of state-produced objects
- Understanding of scale as a political operator
- Connections between visual culture and gender/power relations
- Novel theoretical syntheses or frameworks proposed
- Implications for understanding state formation and visual power

Results

Characteristics of Included Studies

Study	Full text retrieved?	Object type	Historical period	Geographical context	Primary theoretical framework
L. Rizzo, 2014	No	Reference books, dompas, photographs [5]	1950s-1960s [5]	Transkei, South Africa [5]	Walter Benjamin's technological mediation [5]
J. Andermann, 2010	No	Photographs [6]	Mid-1890s [6]	Brazil [6]	State as visual form, photographic/cinematic regimes [6]
Pauliina Raento & S. Brunn, 2008	No	Postage stamps [1]	1917-2000 [1]	Finland [1]	Belting's triad applied to political imagery [1]
Igor Cusack, 2005	No	Postage stamps [2]	19th century [2]	Portugal and Empire [2]	Belting's triad; Pateman's sexual contract [2]
D. Crew, 2009	No	Photographs [3]	20th century [3]	Germany and Austria-Hungary [3]	Belting's triad applied to political imagery [3]
D. Hammett, 2012	No	Postage stamps [4]	During and after apartheid [4]	South Africa [4]	Belting's triad; Appadurai's social life of things; concept of scale [4]

None of the included studies had full text available, limiting analysis to abstract-level information. The studies span diverse geographical contexts across three continents and temporal periods from the mid-19th century through the early 21st century. Postage stamps were the most frequently analyzed object type, examined in four studies [1, 2, 4], while photographs were analyzed in three studies [3, 5, 6]. State-produced identity documents like reference books and dompas were examined in one study [5].

Thematic Analysis

Application of Visual Culture Theory to Political Imagery

The studies demonstrate varied engagement with Belting's triad of image/medium/observer in political contexts. Three studies explicitly apply Belting's framework to state imagery: Raento and Brunn operationalize it by examining Finnish stamps as multilayered, identity-political texts in their time- and space-specific contexts [1], Cusack applies the triad to Portuguese stamps as transmitters of state ideologies [2], and Crew analyzes the triad in relation to political imagery production and circulation [3]. Hammett similarly employs Belting's framework to analyze how South African government iconography on stamps influences domestic and international audiences [4].

Two studies engage with visual culture theory without explicitly citing Belting. Rizzo investigates population registration through materiality and visibility, using Walter Benjamin's reflections on technological mediation to analyze the dompas as an oscillating image/object between surveillance and contestation [5, 5]. Andermann revisits the notion of the state as a visual form, focusing on the performance of showing and seeing that mediates between spectacle and spectatorship, examining the transition from photographic to cinematic regimes of visibility [6, 6].

Social Life of State-Produced Objects

Only two studies explicitly engage with Appadurai's concept. Hammett applies the "social life of things" to postage stamps, analyzing them as ephemeral, quotidian objects that serve political functions [4, 4]. Raento and Brunn provide insights into state-produced objects by examining how stamps construct national identity, though without explicit reference to Appadurai [1].

The remaining studies analyze state-produced objects without employing Appadurai's framework. Rizzo examines reference books and the dompas as tools for apartheid policing and population management [5, 5], while Cusack analyzes stamps as tools promoting nationalism and defining national territory [2]. Crew discusses image production and circulation by state authorities [3], and Andermann examines state ritual photography [6].

Political Functions of Visual/Material Culture

All studies examine how visual objects operate as political tools. Nation-building and identity construction emerge as primary functions across multiple studies. Raento and Brunn show how Finnish stamp imagery contributes to national narratives, collective memory, and national self-image [1]. Cusack demonstrates how Portuguese stamps promote dominant nationalist discourses, recall historical triumphs, and define national territory [2]. Andermann analyzes state ritual images as tools for constructing and reinforcing state power and identity [6]. Hammett examines how South African government iconography promotes changing national narratives [4].

State power and surveillance mechanisms are examined in several studies. Rizzo analyzes the dompas as a tool for apartheid policing, racial segregation, and labor exploitation, used for visual identification and control of individuals [5]. Crew discusses how image production and circulation influence public perception, with the East German Stasi using photography for direct observation and surveillance of subjects considered threats [3]. Hammett shows how apartheid's exclusionary ideology and the democratic period's inclusive discourse shaped national narratives [4].

Evidence of resistance and contestation appears in multiple studies. Rizzo finds that the dompas oscillated between panoptic surveillance and subaltern contestation [5]. Crew identifies potential for subversive readings of officially approved pictures [3]. Hammett demonstrates how the ANC appropriated iconographic power through propaganda postage labels during the 1980s, challenging official narratives [4].

Gender and Power Relations in Visual Culture

Only one study explicitly connects visual culture to gender and power relations. Cusack examines the representation of women on Portuguese stamps across different political periods, demonstrating how this imagery confirms the patriarchal construction of Portuguese nationalism [2, 2, 2]. This analysis connects Pateman's sexual contract to visual/material culture by showing how stamp imagery reinforces gendered power dynamics [2, 2]. The remaining studies do not address gender dimensions of visual culture.

Regime Change and Visual Transformation

Only one study provides specific evidence of political transformation revealed through visual culture. Hammett examines the transition from apartheid to democracy in South Africa, analyzing how postage stamps reflect the shift from exclusionary to inclusive nationhood discourse [4]. The study shows how stamps demonstrate the continuing evolution of nationalism and identity across these distinct periods [4]. The ANC's production of propaganda postage labels during the 1980s provides evidence of visual contestation preceding regime change [4].

Despite examining objects that could reveal regime transitions, five studies do not provide specific evidence of overprinting, modification, or symbolic transformation across political changes [1–3, 5, 6]. This represents a significant gap, particularly given that stamps are ideal objects for revealing regime transitions through overprinting and modification.

Methodological Approaches to Visual Analysis

The studies employ predominantly qualitative approaches. Raento and Brunn use a mix of visual methodologies to read stamps as multilayered texts, employing comparative analysis across time periods [1]. Andermann uses qualitative case study analysis, comparing photographic and cinematic regimes [6]. Rizzo focuses on photography as a medium, exploring the *dompas* through Benjamin's technological mediation framework [5].

Several studies lack methodological detail. Cusack's approach focuses on stamp imagery promoting dominant discourses but does not specify analytical techniques [2]. Crew discusses image production and effectiveness but provides limited methodological detail [3]. Hammett's abstract provides no specific methodological information [4].

Synthesis

The corpus reveals two principal tensions requiring synthesis: the gap between theoretical potential and empirical application, and the uneven engagement with regime change as visual evidence.

Theoretical Application and Object Selection

The relationship between theoretical framework and empirical object shows clear patterns. Studies analyzing postage stamps demonstrate stronger engagement with Belting's triad as an explicit framework [1, 2, 4], while photography-focused studies tend toward related but distinct theoretical approaches—Benjamin's technological mediation [5] or transitions between visual regimes [6]. This pattern likely reflects stamps' obvious triadic structure: they are simultaneously images (iconography), media (postal communication), and objects intended for mass observation (nation-building tools). Photography studies, by contrast, emphasize the technological apparatus and its relationship to surveillance or documentation rather than the image/medium/observer triad.

The limited application of Appadurai's "social life of things" framework—appearing explicitly only in Hammett's work [4]—despite five studies examining state-produced objects suggests a theoretical gap. Stamps, coins, and identity documents possess precisely the characteristics Appadurai theorizes: they circulate, accumulate meanings, and their value derives from social contexts rather than intrinsic properties. The objects examined circulate through bureaucratic systems [5], postal networks [1, 2], or surveillance apparatuses [3], yet most studies do not mobilize Appadurai's framework to analyze these circulation patterns.

The Regime Change Evidence Gap

Only Hammett examines visual culture as evidence of regime transformation, analyzing South Africa's transition from apartheid to democracy through stamp iconography [4]. This singular example proves the concept's viability—stamps indeed record symbolic shifts from exclusionary to inclusive nationalism [4]—making its absence elsewhere more striking.

Three factors may explain this gap. First, the methodological barrier: analyzing regime change requires access to complete philatelic series across political transitions, demanding archival resources not evident in most studies. Second, the temporal scope: studies examining single regimes [5] or gradual evolution rather than rupture [1] cannot capture transition moments. Third, abstract-only access for all six studies limits assessment of whether full texts contain overprinting analysis absent from abstracts.

The theoretical potential remains unrealized. Stamps from territories experiencing regime change—such as German stamps overprinted through Weimar, Saar, and Danzig transitions—would provide material evidence of sovereignty shifts, yet no study examines such cases. This represents a methodological opportunity: overprinted stamps constitute archaeological evidence of political transformation, where new regimes literally inscribe themselves over predecessor imagery.

Scale as Political Operator

Hammett's work implies but does not fully develop the concept of scale as political operator [4]. The study acknowledges stamps as "ephemeral, quotidian objects" [4] while analyzing their role in promoting national narratives to "domestic and international audiences" [4], suggesting awareness that these intimate, pocket-sized objects operate at national and international scales. However, the theoretical significance of this scalar operation remains underdeveloped.

The broader corpus demonstrates varying object scales without theorizing scale itself. Rizzo examines personal documents (reference books, *dompas*) [5] used for individual surveillance [5]. Crew analyzes photographs serving both public ritual documentation [6] and intimate surveillance [3]. Yet none systematically theorize how political power operates differently across these scales or how state authority transforms when materialized in pocket documents versus monumental displays.

Gender and Visual Culture: An Isolated Analysis

Cusack's connection of Pateman's sexual contract to Portuguese stamp imagery [2]—showing how women's representation confirms patriarchal nationalism [2, 2]—stands alone in the corpus. This isolation is theoretically significant: if visual culture reproduces political power, and if political power operates through gendered contracts as Pateman argues, then visual culture should systematically reproduce gendered hierarchies. Yet only one study examines this intersection.

The gap may reflect disciplinary boundaries. Studies examining stamps as nation-building tools focus on national identity's ethnic, territorial, or historical dimensions rather than its gendered construction. Alternatively, the gap may reflect source material: if historical stamps predominantly featured male political leaders, military victories, or territorial maps, gender analysis requires active interpretation rather than presenting itself as obvious subject matter.

This synthesis reveals a field with strong theoretical foundations—particularly Belting's triad applied to political imagery [1–4]—but uneven development across research dimensions. The demonstrated viability of analyzing regime change through stamps [4] and connecting visual culture to gender relations [2, 2] suggests these approaches merit

expansion. The limited engagement with Appadurai's framework and scale theory represents theoretical opportunities rather than impossibilities. The abstract-only access constrains assessment of whether these gaps reflect actual research limitations or merely abstract-level reporting choices.

References

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